

YOUTH COMMUNITY CONNECTION FUND



Final Report

Prepared by
Group C4

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01

Final Report



uOttawa

Created by Group C4:

Abieyuwa Edison-Edebor – York Faculty of Environmental and Urban Change (EUC)
Colin Gordon – uOttawa Faculty of Engineering
Gracey Mann – York Faculty of Health
Mujtaba Shahid – York Lassonde School of Engineering and Computer Science
Samele Zhang – uOttawa Faculty of Engineering
Sondos Qaoud – York Earth and Space Science Engineering

With Advisory Support From:

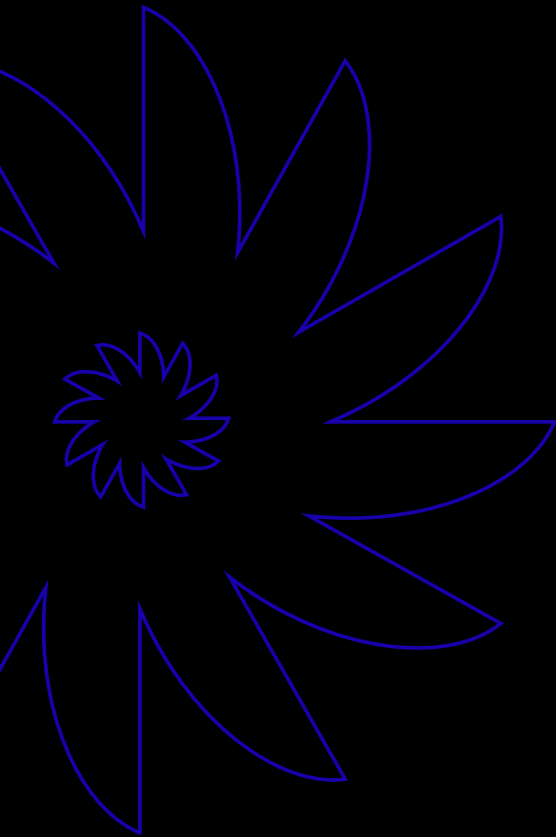
Housing, Infrastructure, & Communities Canada (HICC),
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and the C4 Community



Canada



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Project Statement



The YCCF at a Glance

The Youth Community Connection Fund is a proposed flexible funding initiative that helps youth experiencing housing instability access community-based activities by covering barriers to entry such as fees, transportation, equipment, and supplies. The primary objective of this fund is to support belonging, confidence, life-skills development, and stronger community connections as youth transition toward an independent adulthood.

16–24 ↙

Target age range

5 ↙

Activity categories

32+ ↙

Ottawa-based
activity providers
mapped

Hobbies should not be a privilege.

For youth facing housing instability, access to sports, arts, volunteering, and skill-building programs can create belonging, confidence, and connection.

Project Statement

An Overview of the YCCF

Problem

Youth who are experiencing - or are at risk of - homelessness may receive support for immediate needs such as housing, food, and healthcare, but often still face barriers to community involvement. Without access to community-building activities, youth may experience isolation and fewer opportunities to build durable relationships outside of institutional settings.

Need

Many community activities require costs such as registration fees, equipment, memberships, and/or transportation. For youth experiencing housing instability or financial hardship, these costs serve as barriers to participation. Partner discussions suggest youth-serving organizations often lack discretionary funding for community-building activities.

Goal

The goal of the YCCF is to reduce financial barriers to community participation. This supports youth in the development of durable relationships, routines, confidence, transferable skills, and a stronger sense of belonging in their community.

Scope

The proposed pilot would support youth aged 16-24 who are experiencing homelessness, housing instability, financial difficulty, or a heightened risk of homelessness. The fund would cover activity-related costs through an existing youth-serving organization. Current resources focus on the Ottawa region, however the YCCF is project that can be applied anywhere.

Boundaries

The YCCF is not a housing program, medical service, or a replacement for any existing services. It is intended to supplement existing youth-support services, akin to employment services at youth drop-in centres. The fund would not cover unsafe or discriminatory activities, gambling, or expenses unrelated to community participation.

Stakeholders

Key stakeholders include:

- Youth experiencing housing/financial instability
- Youth-serving organizations (shelters, drop-ins)
- Activity providers
- Community organizations
- Funders
- Potential pilot project hosts

Relevant Sustainable Development Goals

3 GOOD HEALTH AND WELL-BEING



4 QUALITY EDUCATION



8 DECENT WORK AND ECONOMIC GROWTH



10 REDUCED INEQUALITIES



11 SUSTAINABLE CITIES AND COMMUNITIES



Project Justification

How Research Findings Shaped the Design

Research on youth homelessness shows that young people require more than housing support alone. Youth experiencing homelessness often face multiple intersecting challenges, such as mental health concerns, substance use challenges, family conflict, and financial instability (Government of Canada, 2024). Additionally, local partner discussions and visits to the Youth Services Bureau's young women's shelter & drop-in centre uncovered the lack of discretionary funding for community-building activities. This narrowed the YCCF's focus towards building community belonging for youth experiencing or at risk of homelessness.

The Housing First for Youth model emphasizes that stable housing alone is not sufficient for positive outcomes; it must be accompanied by age-appropriate supports relating to health, education, employment, life skills, and social inclusion (Gaetz, 2017). Similarly, youth homelessness prevention research supports a holistic approach, focusing on helping youth stabilize housing, improve well-being, connect with community, and avoid re-entry into homelessness (Gaetz et al. 2024). These findings helped shape the design of the YCCF as a supplementary service that could operate within existing youth-serving organizations.

Further research found that stronger community belonging was positively associated with flourishing mental health among youth (Kerai et al. 2025). This supported the decision to focus on community-based activities, such as sports, arts, volunteering, recreation, education, and skill-building programs as pathways to improving youth connection, confidence, routine, and support.

Project Justification

How Feedback & Roadblocks Shaped the Design

Preliminary feedback identified the need to ensure activity providers provide safe and inclusive environments for youth to avoid discrimination. This led to the development of detailed activity provider approval guidelines, and suggested eligible activities across different categories.

Further development required researching different activities available to youth, along with their associated costs. A major roadblock was identifying a target area to focus on; since an in-person visit to YSB Ottawa was a major source of inspiration for the YCCF, the team decided to focus on Ottawa service providers. This led to the development of an activity provider directory for the Ottawa region. The development of this directory showed that different activities have widely varied costs, which pushed the development of a tiered funding model & application system to support youth in accessing activities across different categories.

Additionally, partner feedback regarding funding sources and details concerning implementing the YCCF became fuel for the creation of a pilot project implementation plan. The plan aimed to cover the fine details of implementing a small pilot project, including funding strategies, partnerships, budgeting, staffing, participant experiences, outcomes, and more.

As the development of the YCCF progressed, the team's uncertainty over the impact of the plan grew. This led to the development of more tangible deliverables, including an interest flowchart to help guide youth towards an activity, a website to organize the activity provider directory, and a refined directory of free activity providers (Youth Community Compass). The development of these tools were in an effort to create useful stand-alone community resources should the YCCF fall short in its implementation of a pilot project.

Project Design Thinking

SOUnd Thinking Approach

The YCCF was developed while emphasizing sustainable, out-of-the-box, and universal design thinking (SOUnd Thinking). By brainstorming, performing in-depth research using the ‘Five Whys’ format, and SPRINT board planning, the team was able to move from a broad concern about youth homelessness service gaps towards a focused and practical project model. Three SPRINT boards were used throughout the course to divide tasks, assign responsibilities, and track progress across research, provider searching, website development, directory creation, implementation planning, and creation of youth-oriented tools.

The project was designed to be sustainable by building on existing youth-serving organizations rather than creating a new standalone organization. In terms of financial sustainability, the creation of funding tiers and implementation plans were used to design a sustainable project. Socially, it aims to support durable relationships, community belonging, and broadened support networks, helping youth to build and sustain valuable connections. While the initial pilot research focuses on Ottawa, the project’s framework can be applied to other communities using local providers, making it sustainable to scale.

The project was intentionally out-of-the-box as it focuses on a hidden part of youth homelessness support, being the access to hobbies, recreation, volunteering, arts, education, and skill-building. Instead of proposing only traditional supports like housing or shelters, the YCCF treats community participation as a meaningful part of holistic youth support. Universal design was also considered through broad activity categories, the ability for youth to choose their own activities, enrollment/transportation/equipment support, and provider approval guidelines that emphasize safety, inclusion, accessibility, and belonging.

Project Design Thinking

Constraints, Criteria, and Alternatives Considered

Several constraints shaped the project's design. The course timeline was very short, so the final solution needed to be realistic, focused, and clear enough for a third party to understand and potentially build upon. The team also struggled to directly launch a fund, secure long-term funding, or create a new service system. This led to the design of the YCCF implementation plan and support resources, requiring an existing youth-serving organization to host or pilot the project.

During the brainstorming stage, the team needed to focus on specific criteria to develop a feasible plan. Since the fund would depend on grants, donations, or partnerships, the model needed to include spending limits, approval processes, and realistic funding pathways. Potential solutions were evaluated based on feasibility, inclusivity, and originality to ensure standards were maintained in the development of the YCCF.

The team considered multiple alternatives before selecting the YCCF. One early idea was a standardized exit strategy for youth transitioning out of homelessness services, which would require coordination across multiple service providers, funders, and government systems. A second idea was a housing + employment pathway, although it would require substantial subsidies, landlord partnerships, employment placements, and administration to realize. These alternative ideas helped clarify that the strongest solution would be a flexible fund supported by practical tools, which was a tangible goal as opposed to broad systemic reforms.

While the true scope of the YCCF was not implemented during the course, the team ensured to use informed decision-making to validate the feasibility of the project. Conducted research helped to confirm the importance of social inclusion for youth, and partner feedback and site visits helped to shape the project by identifying community participation and discretionary funding as practical areas of need. The final direction that the YCCF took aimed to strike a balance between ambition and practicality, attempting to holistically support community belonging and support rather than solving youth homelessness as a whole.

The YCCF In Whole

(The Project Itself)



YCCF Implementation Plan

The YCCF is a project which contains multiple deliverables, including a website, graphics, and detailed guidelines about how the YCCF could run (as shown below). For full details, scan the QR code to view the **YCCF Implementation Plan**, aiming to cover all aspects relevant to realizing the Youth Community Connection Fund.



Scan Here to access the
YCCF Implementation Plan



Youth Community Compass
A free Ottawa resource directory to foster community, connection, and growth.

Sports & Recreation

Provider	Offerings	Age	Registration
City of Ottawa: Play Free	Free Saturday drop-ins: swimming, skating, basketball, table tennis, badminton, volleyball, soccer, open gym, indoor soccer, roller skating and more.	Up to 17	Ottawa.ca Search "Play Free"
BSC Ottawa	Hockey, basketball, and aquatic programs & drop-ins	6-18	BSCOttawa.org
The Clear Youth Centre	Basketball, Boxing, Yoga, Pool Table, Ping Pong, Football	12-18	TheClearYouthCentre.com

Arts & Culture

Provider	Offerings	Age	Registration
School of Photographic Arts	Free beginners digital arts classes: Photography, editing, etc...	18-20	SPOA.ca
Ottawa Public Library	Arts & crafts, book clubs, Bookstore showings, and more!	All Ages	888xOttawaLibrary.ca
Ottawa Art Gallery	Creative Sundays (arts & crafts) & Youth Council (free workshops, events, & projects)	All Ages & 15-25	OGAG.Org
Ottawa Intercity Museum	Intercity Arts: Arts programming with workshops, creative space, and more!	16-22	Ottawaintercitymuseum.ca

Employment & Life Skill Building

Provider	Offerings	Age	Registration
YSB Employment Services	Personalized help to obtain valuable life skills and to connect with employment opportunities	16-24	YSB.ca Look for "Employment Services"
Employment Works Ottawa	One-on-one employment and life-skill building services	16-29	EmploymentWorksOttawa.ca
Operation Come Home	Intensive employment preparation programs	16-29	OperationComeHome.ca

STEM and Education

Provider	Offerings	Age	Registration
Ottawa Public Library	Free to access maker space and science & technology workshops	Events dependent	BiblioOttawaLibrary.ca
UOttawa: Technovation Girls	Free entrepreneurship workshop for those who identify as a girl or non-binary	15-18	UOttawa.ca Search "Technovation"

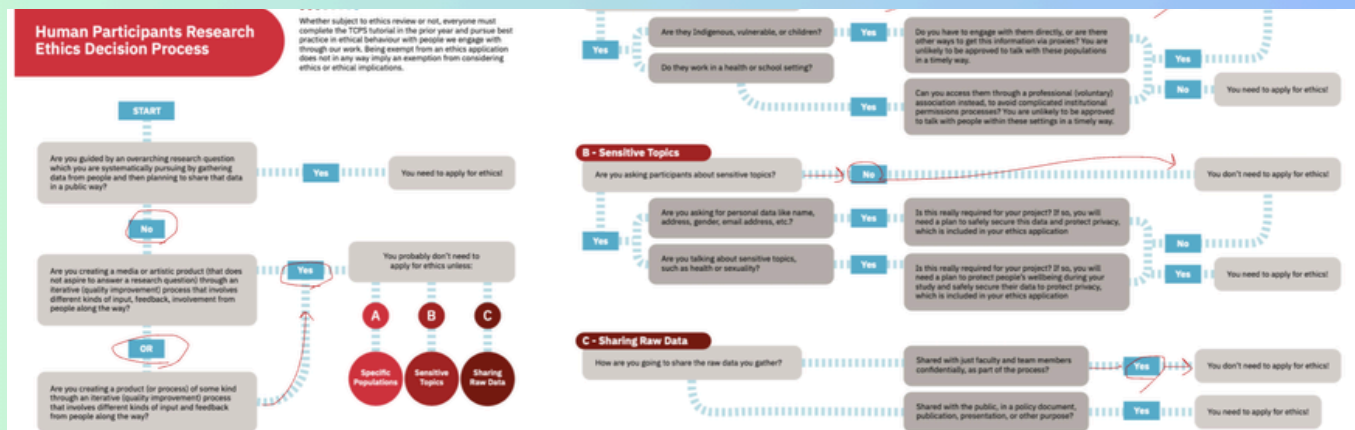
Community Engagement & Volunteering

Provider	Offerings	Age	Registration
Volunteer Ottawa	Volunteering for many events, including cleanups, sports events, and festivals	Events dependent	VolunteerOttawa.ca
City of Ottawa	Volunteer opportunities for public life & health services, arts & culture, and more	Position dependent	Ottawa.ca Search "Volunteering"

Ethics Statement

Ethics Decision Process

Ethics considerations began with filling out an ethics roadmap, as shown below. Through this, it was shown that our work did not involve human participant research; those of vulnerable populations were not directly involved in this project. Rather, it analyzed other, already public, research and data.



Ethics of Care

Throughout the project, we focused on maintaining an ethics of care, but for the project itself as related to its goals, as well as within ourselves as we worked on the project. We emphasized empathy, interpersonal connections, and context over rigidity and universal rules. For example, one of our original considerations for a solution involved the standardization of rules. During one feedback session, we were made aware that it may be a solution that involves ignoring context. With that awareness in mind, our project changed course to a more context-aware solution. Each time we got more feedback, we tweaked things to better align with core values such as inclusivity, diversity, and equity. This process is highlighted in several different sections of the implementation plan, such as in the risks and mitigations section.

The flexibility was extended to our team itself. Our team, made up of diverse members, brought unique perspectives to the table. Everyone participated in contributing these perspectives, and everyone's ideas were joined and built upon, not excluded.

Connection to SDG Goals

3 GOOD HEALTH AND WELL-BEING 	The YCCF supports SDG 3 by promoting mental health well-being, social connection, and healthy routines for youth experiencing housing instability. By helping these youth to access recreation, arts, sports, and skill-building activities, the fund creates opportunities for youth to belong in their community, supporting the development of support networks outside of institutional settings.
4 QUALITY EDUCATION 	SDG 4 would be indirectly positively impacted by the YCCF by improving youth access to informal learning opportunities, including STEAM programs, workshops, leadership activities, and life-skill building programs. These opportunities can help youth build confidence, personal growth, and future education pathways.
8 DECENT WORK AND ECONOMIC GROWTH 	The activities supported by the YCCF directly help youth in building transferable skills relevant to employment and adulthood. Volunteering, leadership programs, sports, arts, and skill-building activities help to support improvement in communication, teamwork, responsibility, confidence, and ultimately career readiness.
10 REDUCED INEQUALITIES 	The YCCF strongly aligns with SDG 10 by reducing financial barriers of entry to community activities for youth experiencing homelessness, housing instability, or financial hardship. The fund aims to make activities such as sports, arts, recreation, and volunteering more accessible to youth who may otherwise be excluded because of cost. Additionally, the vetting process for activity providers ensures a safe and inclusive space for all youth.
11 SUSTAINABLE CITIES AND COMMUNITIES 	The YCCF supports SDG 11 by helping youth to connect within their local communities. By linking youth to Ottawa-based activity providers, community organizations, volunteering opportunities and recreational spaces, the project encourages inclusion, belonging, and participation in community life, building a strong and sustainable community from the bottom up.

Process of Completion

As discussed in section 3, Project Design Thinking, the YCCF was developed quickly over the 2 week C4 course; tools like SPRINT boards, partner feedback, and research findings were used to identify areas of focus, allowing the team to collaborate effectively in the realization of the YCCF.

A breakdown of major contributions to the project by each team member is as follows:

Colin Gordon

- Conceptualization & research of potential solutions (YCCF/standardized exit)
- Midway/final report and implementation plan formatting & design
- Leading in-person Ottawa partner visits
- Researching Ottawa activity providers & creation of the Community Compass
- Working on team workbook tasks & deliverables (Elevator pitch, 5 whys, retrospectives, SPRINT planning)
- Team task planning & delegation of responsibilities
- Implementation Plan - research & writing for the following sections:
 - 'The Problem'
 - 'Research Findings & Evidence Base'
 - Storytelling (participant experience)
 - Tiered funding approach
 - Staffing & roles
 - Risk assessment/mitigation
 - Outputs/outcomes
 - Funding strategy
 - Conclusion/next steps
- Final report:
 - Title page & TOC
 - Statement
 - Justification
 - Design Thinking

Mujtaba Shahid

- Research and conceptualization of potential solutions (standardization)
- Presenting and answering presentation questions
- Timekeeping
- Synthesizing feedback
- Relaying clarifications of tasks from instructors to the team
- Working on team workbook deliverables
- Drafting one of the initial problem statements
- Printing and bringing the deliverable report
- Researching Ottawa activity providers
- Creating a YCCF website
- Working on stand-up presentations and the elevator pitch
- Implementation plan:
 - Storytelling (participant experience)
 - Example pilot project budget
 - Risk assessment/mitigation
 - Potential sources of funding
- Final Report:
 - Proofreading
 - Ethics statement
 - Professional project video
 - Process of completion

Process of Completion

Gracey Mann

- Developed Supplemental Funding Application Form
- Conceptualized potential limitations
- Contributed meaningfully to Team Workbook & deliverables (SPRINT board, elevator pitch, and team charter)
- Created and designed graphics for the activity guide flowchart for youths
- Designed the Activity Provider Approval Guidelines
- Researched and wrote the problem section of the midway report
- Worked on the interdisciplinary reflection for the final report
- Designed the capstone day poster

Abieyuwa Edison-Edebor

- Researched and conceptualized the initial objective of the Youth Community Connection Fund (YCCF).
- Contributed meaningfully to the early Miro Boards.
- Took notes during the kick-off presentation (Feedback from Partners).
- Provided C4 kick-off presentation slide deck.
- Verbally contributed meaningful comments and feedback during the initial planning process of the Implementation Plan.
- **Implementation Plan**
 - Wrote YCCF statement
 - Wrote the Proposed Program Model

Samele Zhang

- **Synthesizing site visit notes**
- **Working on team workbook tasks**
- **Providing administrative information**

Sondos Qaoud

- **Proofreading and providing feedback on the midway report**
- **Advising the group on following assignment expectations**
- **Presentation formatting**
- **Providing feedback on the implementation plan**

Process of Completion

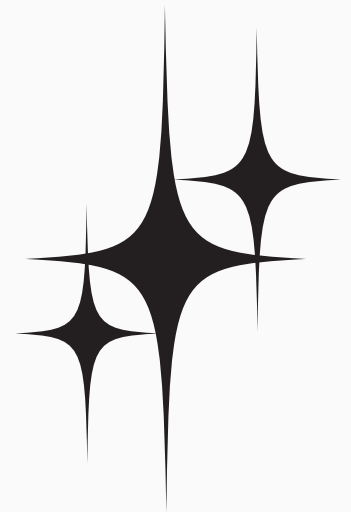
The Process, Explained

The root of the project was the 5 whys board. This was where we took a general problem statement, researched potential 'whys,' and kept researching 'whys' for the 'whys' until we narrowed it down to two specific problems: a lack of community involvement and a lack of standardization. We then researched these two topics more and created a midway report, as well as a short presentation based on our findings. As mentioned in the ethics of care section, we received feedback that made us focus on community involvement. This idea specifically evolved into a community connection fund due to the Ottawa partner visit. Due to our focus on youth, it was rebranded as the YCCF.

Then began the sprints. Day 1 was mostly planning. Some things that got done were mapping a rough service flow and deciding on which city to focus the plan on initially. Day 2 kicked off a lot of tasks, mostly regarding researching and creating guidelines. The major things accomplished were the creation of the activity directory with costs, as well as activity provider approval guidelines and a management plan.

Day 3 was when the big projects happened. Everyone had a different major task to work on, and we all completed our tasks on time. These tasks included the implementation plan, website, flow charts, infographics, and a supplemental application. Day 4 was simply putting together all of the work.

Finally, the project was revised and tweaked one final time using the feedback from the demo presentation day. This included tightening management descriptions, clearing up roles, and adding additional sections to the risks and mitigations.



Interdisciplinary Reflection

Engineering & Computer Science

Two of the team members, Mujtaba Shahid (Computer Science) and Colin Gordon (Civil Engineering + Computing Technology) utilized their discipline-specific experience to conduct effective research and problem solving. Their contributions were vital in the synthesis of preliminary ideas, including the YCCF, and the foundations to develop the project. Mujtaba's background made him a valuable tool in the development of the YCCF website, acting as a centralized way to access all of the work that the team has worked tirelessly on. Additionally, their research skills proved valuable in the creation of activity directories and in report writing.

Health

Gracey Mann (Psychology) used her discipline-specific knowledge to guide the project's focus on youth well-being, belonging, and mental health. Her understanding of psychology helped shape the Youth Community Connection Fund as not only a financial support model but also an intervention aimed at reducing isolation and strengthening psychosocial outcomes for youth experiencing housing instability. She also contributed key insights on the importance of supportive relationships, routine, and community engagement as protective factors, which informed the emphasis on accessible, community-based activities.

Environmental and Urban Change

Abieyuwa Edison-Edebor (Cities, Regions, Planning) used her discipline to guide the project toward its main goal of developing a strong community through social networking. This helped shape the main goal/objective of the Youth Community Connection Fund. The importance of youths, just like the average adult, is that they thrive on strong social connections in various public spaces; they benefit from interactions with other like-minded youths. Without it, isolation is inevitable. In planning, isolation can result in the poor functioning of a city, the same can be applied in the creation of the Youth Community Connection Fund through accessible community-based activities.

Professional Project Video

The team created a one-minute video to encapsulate the project. The video can be accessed on the homepage of the official project website, linked below.

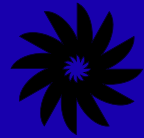
<https://sites.google.com/view/youthcommunityconnectionfund/home>



Team photo

Appendix

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All of the resources created are available on the YCCF website. For high-quality direct downloads, scan the QR codes below.

<https://sites.google.com/view/youthcommunityconnectionfund/>

***YCCF
Implementation Plan***



***Community Compass
(Free Ottawa Activities)***



***Supplemental Funding
Application Form***



Interest Flowchart



References

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